

Why Waiting Is Torture

By Alex Stone

Some years ago, **executives**(执行者, 其实就是经理) at a Houston airport faced a troubling customer - relations issue. Passengers were **lodging**(=register) an **inordinate**ⁱ number of complaints about the long waits at **baggage claim**(行李提取处).ⁱⁱ **In response**, the executives increased the number of baggage handlers working that shift. The plan worked: the average wait fell to eight minutes, well within industry **benchmarks**(=standards). But the complaints **persisted**ⁱⁱⁱ.

- i. Inordinate means exceeding/surpassing reasonable limits, being beyond expectation, 超乎预期的, 超出预期的;
- ii. Sentence 2 can be paraphrased into: Travelers were registering an excessive number of complaints about the long wait spent at the carousel.
- iii. Persist means to continue to exist, 持续不断;

Puzzled, the airport executives **undertook** a more careful, **on-site**ⁱⁱⁱ analysis. They found that it took passengers a minute to walk from their arrival gates to baggage claim and seven more minutes to get their bags. **Roughly**(=about, approximately) 88 percent of their time, in other words, was spent standing around waiting for their bags.

- iv. On-site means at the place where an event happens, e.g. on-site services, 一些现场服务.

So the airport decided on a new **approach**: instead of reducing wait times, it moved the arrival gates away from the main terminal(主航站楼) and **routed**^v bags to the **outermost carousel**^{vi}. Passengers now had to walk six times longer to get their bags. Complaints dropped(=reduced) to near zero.

- v. Route means to send through a chosen direction, or to deliver following a selected way, 按照既定路子传送;
- vi. Outermost means the most outer, 最外头的, 最边边的; carousel 原意指旋转木马, 如下图所示。后来, 其语义延伸, 指代的是飞机场行李提取的大转盘处。



This story **hints at**(=suggest, mean in an indirect way 意味着) a general principle: the experience of waiting, whether for luggage or groceries, is **defined**(=determine, dictate, govern) only partly by the objective length of the wait.^{vii} “Often the **psychology** of **queuing** is more important than the statistics of the wait itself,” **notes**^{viii} the M.I.T. operations researcher Richard Larson, widely considered to be the world’s **foremost**^{ix} expert on lines. **Occupied** time (walking to baggage claim) feels shorter than unoccupied time (standing at the carousel). Research on queuing has shown that, **on average**, people **overestimate** how long they’ve waited in a line **by**^x about 36 percent.

vii. “The experience of waiting, whether for luggage or groceries, is defined only partly by the objective length of the wait” can be paraphrased into:

The line length does not have the final say on the waiting experience for luggage and groceries alike.

Or

The total time we have to wait only partly determines how we feel about it.

viii. Here, note means indicate, or show. Session - Active verbs 那一讲关于 indicate, argue, demonstrate 这几个语力动词的不同特征大家是否还记得。我们说 indicate 强调研究或观察结果。此处的 note 就表示 indicate, 表示观察或研究结果。

ix. Foremost means being at the most forefront, in the lead;

x. By here is a function word in measurements, 此处是一个表度量的功能词汇, 后面接数字, 又如 The first racehorse surpasses the second by three seconds. 第一匹赛马比第二匹赛马快 3 秒钟。

This is also why one finds mirrors next to elevators. The idea was born during the post-World War II boom(二战后繁荣期) when the spread of high-rises(摩天大楼) led to complaints about elevator delays. The rationale^{xi} behind the mirrors was similar to the one used at the Houston airport: give people something to occupy their time, and the wait will feel shorter. With the mirrors, people could check their hair or slyly^{xii} ogle other passengers. And it worked: almost overnight, the complaints ceased.

xi. Rationale(同学们注意发音) means the underlying reason, 深层原因;

xii. Slyly means in a cunning manner; ogle means to eye with greedy or interested attention. To slyly ogle other passengers means to cunningly look at other elevator-takers.

The drudgery of unoccupied time also accounts in large measure for the popularity of impulse-buy items^{xiii}, which earn supermarkets about \$5.5 billion annually. The tabloids and packs of gum offer relief from the agony(=pain) of waiting.

xiii. Drudgery means boredom, dullness. Account for means to explain. So the first sentence can be paraphrased into:

People are usually bored during the unoccupied time and that may trigger their impulse to buy additionally.

Or

The boredom of unoccupied time is also a main reason for people buying items impulsively.

Our expectations further affect how we feel about lines. Uncertainty magnifies^{xiv} the stress of waiting, while feedback in the form of expected wait times and explanations for delays improves the tenor^{xv} of the experience.

xiv. Magnify means to exaggerate, or to enlarge in fact, 扩大化, 或夸张;

xv. Tenor here means the general way in which an event or process takes place. So the tenor of the experience means the whole waiting experience from the beginning to the end.

And beating expectations buoys our mood^{xvi}. All else being equal, people who wait less than they anticipated leave happier than those who wait longer than expected. This is why Disney, the universally acknowledged master of applied queuing

psychology(应用排队心理学), overestimates wait times for rides, so that its guests — never customers, always guests — are pleasantly surprised when they **ascend(get on)** Space Mountain **ahead of schedule**.

xvi. Beat means to defeat, outdo, outperform. Buoy is originally a noun, meaning “float”, 浮力; here, it is a verb, which means to support, to keep sth afloat.

“Beating expectations buoys our mood” can be paraphrased into:

Surpassing our expectations uplifts our spirit.

This is a powerful **ploy(=tactic, strategy)** because our memories of a queuing experience, to use an industry **term(术语)**, are strongly influenced by the final moments, according to research conducted by Ziv Carmon, a professor of marketing at the business school Insead, and the behavioral economist Daniel Kahneman. When a long wait ends on a happy note — the line speeds up, say — we tend to look back on it positively, even if we were **miserable** much of the time. Conversely, if **negative** emotions **dominate(主宰)** in the final minutes, our **retrospective^{xvii}** audit of the process will **skew toward cynicism^{xviii}**, even if the experience as a whole was **relatively** **painless^{xix}**.

xvii. *Retrospect* is the antonym of *prospect*, 前者为回望, 后者为展望; retrospective is related to retrospection, or based on memory; audit means review, 回顾.

xviii. Skew means to look with an attitude of suspicion. Cynicism here simply means disapproval, complaint.

xix. 老师给同学们提供四种转译方式。The sentence can be paraphrased into:

1. Usually the process of waiting has less impact on people's mood than the result, to which people always pay more attention;
2. When the process ends on a sad note, our review of it will be pessimistic, although the experience was not painful as a whole.
3. Although the whole waiting process is relatively painless, it will leave us a terrible impression because of our negative emotions in the final minutes.
4. On the contrary, even if our whole experience of waiting is not that bad, as long as the last several minutes are negative, we tend to look at it negatively.

Professors Carmon and Kahneman have also found that we are more concerned with how long a line is than how fast it's moving. Given a choice between a slow-moving short line and a fast-moving long one, we will often **opt for^{xx}** the former, even if the waits are **identical**. (This is why Disney hides the lengths of its lines by **wrapping** them around buildings and using **serpentine^{xxii}** queues.)

xx. Opt for 是一个固定搭配, 后面务必接 for. Opt for means to choose, select.

xxi. Wrap 这个词我们本学期碰到了很多回。第一回是在 Session 5 - Description, Sound: The wrapping paper of the cigarette, 表示香烟的包装纸; 第二次出现在 Session 11 - Analogy, Sausages - The two ends of the casings(肠衣) are wrapped up. 表示肠衣两段被扎起来了。Here, in this context, wrap means to wind or fold so as to cover sth up. 表示通过蜿蜒、折叠等形式来尝试遮掩。

xxii. Serpentine means resembling a serpent. 蛇形的。

Perhaps the biggest influence on our feelings about lines, though, has to do with our perception of **fairness**. When it comes to lines, the universally acknowledged

standard is first come first served: any **deviation**^{xxiii} is, to most, a mark of **iniquity**^{xxiv} and can lead to violent **rage**. Last month a man was **stabbed**^{xxv} at a Maryland post office by a fellow customer who mistakenly thought he'd cut in line. Professor Larson calls these unwelcome **intrusions**^{xxvi} "**slips**" and "**skips**."^{xxvii}

xxiii. Deviation means departure from an established ideology, 偏离既定主流意识;

我们讲文章离题, 写偏题了, 也用该词。

xxiv. Iniquity means injustice, wickedness;

xxv. Stab means to pierce(穿透) or wound(使受伤) by using a pointed weapon(尖锐的武器);

xxvi. Intrusion means the act of wrongfully entering into. 侵犯;

xxvii. Slips means the acts of cutting in the queue. 偷偷流进队伍里; skips means the acts of jumping the line. 从后往前插队。

The demand for fairness **extends beyond**(=transcend) mere self-interest. Like any social system, lines are **governed**(=dominate, define, determine) by an **implicit set of norms**^{xxviii} that **transcend** (=extend beyond) the individual. A study of fans in line for U2 tickets found that people are just as upset by slips and skips that occur behind them, and thus don't **lengthen** their wait, as they are by those in front of them.

xxviii. Implicit is the antonym of explicit. It means implied, present but not consciously recognised. 它表示潜在的, 存在而不自知的, 不明文的; a set of norms 一套标准;

Surveys show that many people will wait twice as long for fast food, provided the establishment uses a first-come-first-served, single-queue ordering system **as opposed to**^{xxix} a multi-queue setup. Anyone who's ever had to choose a line at a grocery store knows how unfair multiple queues can seem; **invariably**(=always, continuously), you **wind up**^{xxx} kicking yourself for not choosing the line next to you moving twice as fast.

xxix. As opposed to is a fixed phrase; it is used to indicate difference from what has just been mentioned. E.g. They use fresh fish, as opposed to frozen one.

xxx. Wind up means to come to an end after a course of action. 在采取一系列行为后达到了某种结果。

But there's a curious **cognitive asymmetry** at work here^{xxxi}. While losing to the line at our left drives us to despair, winning the race against the one to our right does little to **lift our spirits**. Indeed, in a system of multiple queues, customers almost always **fixate**(=focus) on the line they're losing to and rarely the one they're beating^{xxxii}.

xxxi. 第一句可以翻译成: 这里就要提到一种有趣的意识不对称现象。Cognitive: related to conscious intellectual activity, 和有意识的智力、思想活动相关的; Symmetry means balanced proportions, 对称结构. Asymmetry is the antonym(反义词).

xxxii. The last sentence can be paraphrased into:

Multiple lines are the very source of people's perception of unfairness, as people nearly only keep an eye on the line moving faster instead of the one moving slower than theirs.

Fairness also **dictates**^{xxxiii} that the length of a line should **be commensurate**^{xxxiv}

with the value of the product or service for which we're waiting. The more valuable it is, the longer one is willing to wait for it. Hence(=Therefore, adv.) the supermarket express line^{xxxv}, a rare, socially sanctioned^{xxxvi} violation of first come first served, based on the assumption that no reasonable person thinks a child buying a candy bar should wait behind an old man stocking up on provisions for the Mayan apocalypse.

xxxiii. Dictate means to impose, determine, require necessarily.

xxxiv. Commensurate is an adj., which means equal in measure or extent; be commensurate with simply means to be equal with, to be in line with.

xxxv. 西方超市的快捷通道 Express line 通常规定, 走该通道的顾客手里不得超过 10 样, 或 15 样产品。

xxxvi. Sanction here means to approve of or give consent to, 表示赞同; 那么, "the supermarket express line, a rare socially sanctioned violation..." 可翻译为:

Though the supermarket express line violates "first come first served" rule, its creation is still accepted widely by people, because everyone believes a child with only one thing to buy should stand in a queue before an old man with a great number of products to pay.

其翻译为:

因此(Hence), 超市的快速通道应运而生(老师采用补充完整语义的译法), 它是社会皆认同的(socially sanctioned)、违背先来先得原则的一罕见实例(a rare violation, 一罕见违背, violation 为抽象名词, 那么此处老师采取抽象名词具象化译法, 译成违背某某原则的一实例), 因为任何一个通情达理的人都不会认为一个买棒棒糖的孩子应该排在一位为度过劫难而购买大量食物的老人后面。

Americans spend roughly(=about) 37 billion hours each year waiting in line. The dominant(=main) cost of waiting is an emotional one: stress, boredom, that nagging^{xxxvii} sensation(=feeling) that one's life is slipping away. The last thing we want to do with our dwindling^{xxxviii} leisure time is squander(=waste away, 浪费) it in stasis. We'll never eliminate lines altogether, but a better understanding of the psychology of waiting can help make those inevitable delays that inject themselves into our daily lives a touch(一丝) more bearable.^{xl} And when all else fails, bring a book.

xxxvii. Nagging is a very very negative emotion, which means persistently annoying or finding fault with sb. 总不停找茬的挑剔情绪;

xxxviii. Dwindling means shrinking, becoming less and less;

xxxix. Inevitable means incapable of being avoided, 无法避开的, 无法躲避的;

xl. "...but a better understanding of the psychology of waiting can help make those inevitable delays... a touch more bearable" can be paraphrased into:

...but understanding better how people think and feel when waiting can help change those unpleasant delays into something more acceptable.